



VIGILANT: Members of the village militia in Abujmarh of banned organisations.

Goodru possibly does not fully understand the dangers of associating with the outlawed outfit but 40-year-old Lakshman does. Yet, he shares Goodru's enthusiasm for the PLGA. "Even children who study in schools do not find jobs. They join the movement to fight for basic rights," says Lakshman in Telugu-influenced Hindi. He heads the Maoist village militia across eight villages. The village militia at the bottom of the power hierarchy usually comprise 300 to 400 people capable of using bows and arrows. "They defend the area against invasion by the police or the anti-Maoist Salwa Judum members," says Manu, a dalam representative. About 70 people who keep vigil and spread the political ideology make a dalam. Its members are familiar with country-made firearms and take Mao's words, "political power flows through the barrel of the gun," seriously. The PLGA has recruited women, at par with men, imparting military training and sending them to lead guerrilla squads. Maoist documents claim that 139 women cadre were killed between September 2004 and July 2007 by the police.

The Naxal movement had died out with the death of Charu Mazumdar in 1972 but splinters re-emerged later. One was the erstwhile CPI (M-L) People's War Group (PWG) which held sway over north west Telangana, eastern Maharashtra and western Orissa for over 20 years. Parallel to this, the Maoist Communist Centre of India (MCCI) operated out of central India. The PWG and the MCCI merged to form the CPI (Maoist) in September 2004 when Muppala Lakshmana Roa alias Ganapathy, a school-teacher-turned revolutionary from Andhra Pradesh's Karimnagar district, was elected general secretary. A unity congress was held in late January 2007 inside a forest, attended by the core political and military leadership. It was an important event in the extreme Left calendar as differences of 37 years within the camp appeared to have been resolved. Slogans typed on red pieces of cloth adorned a seminar hall where participants shouted "*ek he rasta*" (only one way). They vowed to inten-

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Their arms training is intense, fashioned after modules of the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), say intelligence officers in Raipur and Dantewada. Unlike the Tigers or Islamic extremists, Indian Maoists are yet to use suicide squads for their offensives. The LTTE connection is being suspected because of the liberal use of landmines and pressure bombs. These were initially used in Andhra Pradesh but are now being deployed in Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand to attack politicians and security personnel. The Maoists support the LTTE as also the separatist campaigns in Kashmir and the North-east which they term "nationalist movements." The CPI (Maoist) is listed at 27 on the Union Home Ministry's list

sify the "people's war" through mobile guerrilla squads. Mao had done so during the Chinese revolution of the 1930s.

This is 21st century India. "When we began the struggle it was a peaceful movement on people's issues such as land, livelihood and liberation from feudal and imperial exploitation and oppression... it was only after peaceful marches, rallies, dharnas, hunger strikes, general strikes went unheeded, or were sought to be crushed, that people were forced to resort to violent methods," says Ganapathy in one of his party circulars. In his opinion, the UPA Government's SEZ policy is aimed at creating "neo colonial enclaves." Party members have mobilised people against proposed SEZs in